

Iowa State - 2026 Preseason Primer

2026 COLLEGE FOOTBALL PRESEASON PRIMER | BIG 12

Legend: trend - ● ↑ better · ● ↔ similar · ● ↓ worse · **assessment** - ● strong/positive · ● average/mixed/uncertain · ● weak/negative · ♦ new player or coach

1. 60-Second Briefing

Initial conclusions

Question	Answer
How good?	Rebuild-year Big 12 team with a clearer quarterback than most of the roster, a potentially functional defense, and enough transfer talent to beat a low baseline-but the combination of 44% returning production, a completely new staff and an offensive line with no proven 2025 starter makes bowl eligibility an uphill projection.
Preseason consensus	AP unranked (0 votes/points) · SP+ No. 69
Returning production	44% (No. 105) overall · Off. 44% (No. 103) · Def. 43% (No. 96)
Primer power rating	-0.5 points vs. average FBS
Expected season	5.1 wins · likely 5-7
Net vs. 2025	● ↓ Worse - Worse and much less stable than the 8-4 2025 team
Confidence	Medium-low

2026 identity: Iowa State is a full roster-and-staff reset around expected QB Jaylen Raynor. OC Tyler Roehl's pro-style offense has a completely rebuilt OL and unsettled WR hierarchy, while DC Jesse Bobbit rebuilds around LB Sullivan Schlimgen, DE Isaac Terrell and a transfer-heavy secondary. Both primary game-day callers remain unresolved.

Bottom line: QB clarity, defensive talent and special-teams stability create upside beyond five wins, but extremely low continuity and unresolved first-unit combinations keep Iowa State a volatile bowl-line team.

Beats expectations if: QB Jaylen Raynor is immediately competent, the transfer-built OL settles quickly and DE Isaac Terrell/LB Sullivan Schlimgen help preserve 2025-level defensive efficiency.

Disappoints if: The OL cannot protect QB Jaylen Raynor, the WR room lacks explosives and the low-continuity defense loses its 2025 efficiency floor.

Five things to remember

- 1 Defense:** Iowa State returns only 44% of production overall (No.105), with both offense (No.103) and defense (No.96) in the bottom third nationally.
- 2 Offensive line:** QB Jaylen Raynor is expected to open as QB1, giving a heavily rebuilt offense a clearer quarterback answer than it has at offensive line or receiver.
- 3 ♦ Roster overhaul:** The offensive line has no proven returning 2025 starter; OL Jake Taylor is the best-defined anchor candidate in a transfer-heavy five-man build.
- 4 ? Key uncertainty:** S Braden Awi and RB Salahadin Allah are still rostered incoming transfers but are out for the season, removing two intended pieces before Week 1.
- 5 ? Play-caller:** Tyler Roehl and Jesse Bobbit are the coordinators, but both primary 2026 game-day play-caller assignments remain unresolved.

2. 2025 in Context

Traditional Stats

Measure	2025	Assessment
Record	8-4 (5-4 Big 12)	● Good
Scoring	27.4 PPG	● Average / mixed
Total offense	396.1 YPG	● Average / mixed
Rush offense	174.7 YPG · 4.4 YPC	● Good / above average
Pass efficiency	7.66 YPA · 16 TD / 9 INT	● Average / mixed
Third downs	40.1%	● Average / mixed
Scoring defense	20.2 PPG allowed	● Very good
Total defense	356.5 YPG allowed	● Average / mixed
Rush defense	138.0 YPG · 4.4 YPC	● Good / above average
Pass defense	218.5 YPG · 6.78 YPA · 14 TD allowed	● Good / above average

The 2025 Cyclones paired a strong scoring/adjusted defense with solid offensive EPA and success rate. Explosiveness lagged, and 2026’s extremely low continuity means that 8-4 profile cannot simply be carried forward.

Advanced Stats

Measure	2025	Assessment
Opp.-adjusted offense	+2.48 · No. 49	● Good / above average
Off. EPA/play	+0.080 · No. 37	● Good / above average
Off. success rate	45.3% · No. 41	● Good / above average
Off. explosive-play rate	11.4% · No. 91	● Below average
Havoc allowed	13.8% · No. 49	● Good / above average
Opp.-adjusted defense	+3.83 · No. 32	● Very good
Def. EPA/play allowed	-0.063 · No. 41	● Good / above average
Def. success rate allowed	40.7% · No. 55	● Average / mixed
Def. explosive-play rate allowed	11.7% · No. 61	● Average / mixed
Havoc created	16.3% · No. 52	● Average / mixed

Advanced-stat read: Adjusted defense No. 32 and offensive EPA No. 37 support the 8-4 record, while offensive explosiveness was the notable weakness. The roster reset makes those efficiency baselines less transferable, especially behind an OL with no proven returning 2025 starter.

EPA and success rate use CFB Graphs regular-season data. Explosive rate uses regular-season non-garbage-time cfbfastR plays; explosive = 10+ yd rush or 20+ yd pass. Havoc = TFL + forced fumbles + passes defended per play. Lower is better for defensive rates and offensive havoc allowed.

3. Coaching

Role	2026 status	Quick impact
HC	◆ Jimmy Rogers - new external hire	● ↓ A full head-coaching reset adds implementation uncertainty to an already low-continuity roster.
OC	◆ Tyler Roehl - new external hire	● ↔ Installing a pro-style offense; primary game-day caller remains unresolved.
DC	◆ Jesse Bobbit - new external hire	● ↔ Leads the rebuilt defense; primary game-day caller remains unresolved.

4. Key Roster Movement

Offense

In	From	Expected effect
◆ QB Jaylen Raynor	Arkansas State	● ↑ Expected QB1 gives the rebuild a defined starting point.
◆ RB Cameron Pettaway	Bowling Green	● ↔ Paul Hornung-recognized lead-role challenger, not a settled workhorse.
◆ OL Jake Taylor	Oklahoma	● ↔ Potential tackle anchor for a unit with no proven returning 2025 starter.
◆ OL Braden Smith	Tarleton State	● ↔ Experienced center candidate in an unsettled interior.
◆ RB Salahadin Allah	Oregon State	● ↔ Material arrival, but a season-ending Achilles injury removes his 2026 contribution.

Out	To	Loss
QB Rocco Becht	Penn State	● ↓ Major QB continuity loss; QB Jaylen Raynor replaces an established starter.
TE Benjamin Brahmer	Penn State	● ↓ Meaningful receiving/blocking loss forces a new TE hierarchy.
RB Carson Hansen	Penn State	● ↓ Backfield production loss increases reliance on RB Aiden Flora/RB Cameron Pettaway.
OL Jim Bonifas	NFL (Miami Dolphins), undrafted free agent	● ↓ Twelve-start center loss deepens the interior reset.
OL Tyler Miller	NFL (Denver Broncos), undrafted free agent	● ↓ Experienced starting-OL loss.
OL James Neal III	NFL (Houston Texans), undrafted free agent	● ↓ Veteran OL loss compounds the no-returning-starter problem.

Offense net: QB Jaylen Raynor is a credible replacement, but OL/skill continuity losses are too broad to call the offense stable. ● ↓

Defense

In	From	Expected effect
◆ DE Isaac Terrell	Washington State	● ↑ Bednarik-recognized edge is the strongest addition to the rebuilt front.
◆ LB Sullivan Schlimgen	Washington State	● ↑ Identified MIKE with starting experience gives the defense a communication anchor.
◆ DT Bryson Lamb	Washington State	● ↔ Major interior piece in a front replacing multiple veterans.
◆ S Micah Harper	Montana	● ↔ Starting-safety candidate gains importance with S Braden Awls out.
◆ CB Seth Johnson	Montana State	● ↔ Starting-corner candidate in a low-continuity secondary.
◆ S Braden Awls	Toledo	● ↔ Material arrival, but a torn ACL removes him from the 2026 role picture.

Out	To	Loss
DT Domonique Orange	NFL (Minnesota), Round 3, No. 82	● ↓ The drafted interior defender is the front's biggest NFL loss.
S Jeremiah Cooper	Penn State	● ↓ Safety loss contributes to a near-total secondary reset.
LB Caleb Bacon	Penn State	● ↓ Experienced LB loss increases dependence on LB Sullivan Schlimgen.
LB Kooper Ebel	Penn State	● ↓ Another meaningful LB loss reduces second-level continuity.
DE Ikenna Ezeogu	Penn State	● ↓ Front-rotation loss adds to the veteran replacement burden.

Defense net: Down in continuity and proven depth, but functional if DE Isaac Terrell/LB Sullivan Schlimgen stabilize the front seven. ● ↓

5. How They Play

Phase	Identity	What works	Main vulnerability
Offense	OC Tyler Roehl's pro-style offense is built around expected QB Jaylen Raynor; game-day caller remains unresolved.	QB Jaylen Raynor and RB Aiden Flora/RB Cameron Pettaway give the rebuild defined backfield pieces.	The OL has no proven returning 2025 starter, and the WR hierarchy remains unsettled.
Defense	DC Jesse Bobbit rebuilds around LB Sullivan Schlimgen and a transfer-heavy front/secondary.	DE Isaac Terrell supplies edge upside and LB Sullivan Schlimgen anchors communication.	Shared continuity is extremely low and S Braden Awls is out, making back-end communication a major risk.
Special teams	Returning placekicker stability with uncertainty at punter.	PK Kyle Konrardy anchors a No. 27 SP+ unit.	K/P Jace Lounsbury's exact role remains unresolved.

6. Unit Grades

Unit	Grade	vs. 2025	Confidence	Why
QB	● B–	● ↓	Medium	QB Jaylen Raynor is the expected QB1, but the supporting cast is being rebuilt.
RB	● C+	● ↓	Medium-low	RB Aiden Flora/RB Cameron Pettaway are credible options, but RB Salahadin Allah is out for the season.
WR	● C+	● ↓	Low	WR Dominic Overby is the likely leader, but most of the rotation is new and unsettled.
TE	● C+	● ↓	Medium-low	The early hierarchy is emerging, but proven Big 12 production remains limited.
OL	● C–	● ↓	Low	No proven 2025 starter returns; OL Jake Taylor is the clearest anchor in a broad rebuild.
DL/Edge	● C+	● ↓	Medium-low	DE Isaac Terrell and newcomers provide usable pieces, but major veteran losses reduce continuity.
LB	● C+	● ↓	Medium-low	LB Sullivan Schlimgen is the MIKE, but substantial veteran production and depth must be replaced.
Secondary	● C	● ↓	Low	Transfer-heavy combinations and S Braden Awls' season-ending injury leave major role/continuity risk.
Special teams	● B	● ↔	Medium-high	PK Kyle Konrardy anchors the No. 27 SP+ unit, though punter remains unsettled.
Coaching	● C+	● ↓	Low	HC Jimmy Rogers, OC Tyler Roehl and DC Jesse Bobbit are all new; both primary callers remain unresolved.
Overall	● C+	● ↓	Medium-low	A -0.5 rating and 5.1-win baseline fit a functional but below-average team with major OL, secondary and staff variance.

7. Players to Know

Recognition status: official conference honors and major award watchlists through Aug. 23, 2026.

Player	Pos.	Evaluation	Preseason recognition	Why he matters
◆ Jaylen Raynor (TR: Arkansas State)	QB	● Functional Power 4 starter projection / rebuild fulcrum	-	Expected QB1; the season ceiling depends heavily on whether he can operate behind a new line without forcing the offense into low-explosiveness patterns.
◆ Isaac Terrell (TR: Washington State)	DE	● High-upside conference edge / defensive centerpiece	Bednarik	Most prominent recognized defensive addition and a key answer to major front-seven turnover.
Aiden Flora	RB	● Projected lead back / continuity piece	-	Most experienced returning RB and early favorite to lead the room.
◆ Cameron Pettaway (TR: Bowling Green)	RB	● Major rotation / lead-role challenger	Paul Hornung	A recognized transfer with a projected major role, making the backfield a true two-player competition rather than a one-man projection.

Player	Pos.	Evaluation	Preseason recognition	Why he matters
◆ Sullivan Schlimgen (TR: Washington State)	LB	● Starting MIKE / defensive communicator	-	Explicitly identified as the MIKE after five 2025 starts at Washington State, making him central to the new defense.
◆ Jake Taylor (TR: Oklahoma)	OL	● Projected tackle anchor	-	Most clearly identified OL anchor candidate in a group with no proven returning 2025 starter.
Dominic Overby	WR	● Projected receiver-room leader	-	One of the few returning offensive role anchors in an otherwise rebuilt pass-catching group.
Kyle Konrardy	PK	● Established specialist anchor	-	Returning placekicker is the clearest source of special-teams continuity on a roster short on it.

8. Schedule

Item	Assessment
Overall	● Moderate nationally, but difficult for a rebuild facing six opponents rated roughly a touchdown stronger plus several top-35 road tests.
Difficulty	● 6/10 · Moderate · SP+ SOS No. 51
Hardest stretch	Utah → West Virginia → at BYU, followed by the bye before another road game at Arizona
Swing games	West Virginia, Cincinnati, at UCF, at Baylor
Advantage	Home games against Southeast Missouri and Bowling Green provide two early stabilization opportunities, and the mid-October bye separates the BYU and Arizona road trips.
Expected	5.1 wins · likely 5-7
Floor / ceiling	3-9 / 8-4

9. Betting Lens

Angle	Read
Market posture	The 8-4 prior record can overstate stability, while rebuild pessimism can also go too far if QB Jaylen Raynor and the defense settle quickly.
Back them when	Opponents cannot create pressure without blitzing, Iowa State protects QB Jaylen Raynor and the price treats the Cyclones below their low-end Power 4 baseline.
Fade/pass when	Strong fronts or explosive passing games can directly attack the unsettled OL and secondary before those combinations prove stable.
Key monitor	final OL five, receiver first-unit hierarchy, WR Ryver Peppers availability, secondary combinations after S Braden Awls injury, offensive and defensive caller attribution
Week 1 baseline	vs. Southeast Missouri: no independent preseason fair line; use the live market as the opening benchmark. Live market: Iowa State –29.5 (CBS Sports, Aug. 25).

10. Summary

Iowa State's rebuild has a useful starting point in expected QB Jaylen Raynor, while DE Isaac Terrell, LB Sullivan Schlimgen and PK Kyle Konrardy give the defense/special teams identifiable anchors. The rest of the roster has unusually little shared continuity.

A new staff, an OL with no proven returning 2025 starter and a transfer-heavy secondary make five wins a sound center. Bowl eligibility becomes much more plausible if the OL settles quickly and the defense preserves some of last year's efficiency.

About this primer

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